Response to "What Is Still Missing for Decidability of $\mathsf{ALCI}_{\mathsf{RCC5}}$?"

Points of agreement, corrections, and an evaluation of the omega-model proposal

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Context. This note responds to the status document by GPT-5.4 Thinking [4], which integrates the $\mathsf{FW}(C, N)$ counterexample [1] with the earlier quasimodel draft [2] and contextual tableau work [5]. We address points of agreement, correct two characterizations of the quasimodel work that we believe are inaccurate, and evaluate the proposed omega-model direction.

1 Points of agreement

We agree with the central conclusions of the status note [4]:

1. **The $\mathsf{FW}(C, N)$ counterexample is definitive.** The strict partial order argument closes the exact-recentering route. No patch to the fixed-width framework can circumvent it, because the obstruction is structural: PP-transitivity, universal propagation of $\forall\mathsf{PP}$ along PP-chains, and the finiteness of any carrier set are jointly incompatible with the recentering axiom (R3).
2. **The (A) / (B) distinction is the right conceptual move.** Separating *strong finiteness* (exact local-state closure with recentering, refuted) from *weak finiteness* (bounded local descriptors around a finite core, possibly still true) correctly identifies what the counterexample does and does not destroy. If the signature-counting result of [3] is correct, it may serve as the finite alphabet for a future decision procedure.
3. **An omega-level mechanism is needed.** The callback to Wessel's "infinity checker" remark [7, p. 49] is apt. Any successful decision procedure for $\mathsf{ALCI}_{\mathsf{RCC5}}$ must explicitly represent infinite PP/PPI-progress rather than trying to compress it into a finite embedding. The analogy with Büchi/parity acceptance for infinite paths is natural and worth developing.
4. **The decidability of $\mathsf{ALCI}_{\mathsf{RCC5}}$ remains open.** Neither the quasimodel route, the contextual tableau route, nor their combination currently yields a decision procedure.

2 Corrections to the characterization of the quasimodel work

Two statements in the status note misrepresent the quasimodel draft [2]. We correct them here.

2.1 The patchwork property is not "misused"

The status note says the quasimodel proof "misuses patchwork at the global amalgamation step" [4, Section 4, Table]. This is inaccurate.

The revised paper [2] uses the patchwork property in exactly the form that applies:

- The *atomic* patchwork property (path-consistent atomic RCC5 networks are globally consistent) is invoked for atomic network extensions.
- The *full RCC5 tractability* result of Renz [6] (path-consistent *disjunctive* RCC5 networks are consistent) is invoked in the revised Claim 5.2 for the disjunctive extension problem.

The paper's acknowledged gap is not that patchwork is misapplied but that the *disjunctive* extension network at each Henkin step may have its domains emptied by path-consistency enforcement when the quasimodel is abstract (not derived from a model). The paper states this explicitly in its extension-gap remark and in the revised abstract. Describing this as a "misuse" conflates an honestly documented open problem with a mathematical error.

2.2 Soundness is proven, not merely "a natural first abstraction"

The status note's table describes the quasimodel work as providing only "[t]he type-level setup is a natural first abstraction." This undersells two solid results:

1. **Soundness** (satisfiable $\Rightarrow$ quasimodel) **is fully proven.** If a concept C_0 is satisfiable, a quasimodel satisfying conditions (Q1)–(Q3) can be extracted from the model. This direction has no gap.
2. **The EXPTIME type-elimination algorithm has no false negatives.** If C_0 is satisfiable, the algorithm accepts. Equivalently: if the algorithm rejects, C_0 is definitely unsatisfiable. This is a non-trivial algorithmic result, not merely a "setup."

For completeness, the comparison should read:

Route	**What is proven**	**What remains open**
Quasimodel [2]	Soundness (satisfiable $\Rightarrow$ quasimodel); EXPTIME algorithm with no false negatives; sound rejection.	Completeness (quasimodel $\Rightarrow$ model): the Henkin extension may fail for abstract quasimodels (extension gap).
Contextual tableau [5]	Soundness (closed family $\Rightarrow$ model) via unfolding.	Completeness ($\mathsf{FW}(C, N)$): **refuted** by [1].

Note that the two soundness results go in *opposite directions*: the quasimodel route proves that satisfiable concepts produce quasimodels (a "soundness of rejection" result), while the contextual tableau proves that accepted abstract objects produce models (a "soundness of acceptance" result). Both are correct; neither is merely a "setup."

3 Evaluation of the omega-model proposal

The status note proposes a "regular omega-model theorem" as the missing ingredient: a representation of models by finitely many local interface signatures, finitely many PP/PPI thread control states, and an acceptance condition for infinite proper-part chains. We evaluate this proposal in three respects.

3.1 The architecture is plausible

For standard $\mathcal{ALCI}$ (without RCC constraints), decidability is established via two-way alternating parity tree automata (2APTAs) running on tree models. The witness structure of an $\mathsf{ALCI}_{\mathsf{RCC5}}$ model is still tree-like — each element has finitely many witnesses, forming a tree when unfolded. The non-tree part consists of cross-edges (RCC5 relations between non-witness-related elements). If the number of relevant "relational profiles" is bounded by a computable function of $|C|$ (the weak finiteness claim), an automaton with finite state could track them, with a parity condition handling infinite PP-chains.

This is architecturally consistent with how μ-calculus extensions of description logics handle infinite paths. The analogy is encouraging.

3.2 The hard parts are not addressed

The status note's four-task roadmap (Section 5 of [4]) identifies what is needed but does not deliver any of it. We highlight the specific difficulties:

1. **Interface transfer** (task 1). "A successor state should preserve only the finite interface to the old context." What is this interface, formally? The recentering axioms (R1)–(R4) were the previous answer, and they are now refuted. A replacement must be defined precisely enough to support both a soundness proof (the accepted abstract object unfolds to a model) and a completeness proof (every model yields an accepted object). Neither definition nor proof is provided.

2. **Omega-acceptance** (task 2). Büchi or parity conditions work on *paths* through a graph. In a complete-graph model, every pair of elements is related by some RCC5 relation. What is the "run" of the automaton? On what structure does the acceptance condition operate? For tree automata, the answer is clear (paths from root to leaves/infinity). For complete-graph models, this needs a non-trivial definition.

3. **Regular extraction** (task 3). This is the core difficulty, and it is essentially the same completeness problem we have been struggling with in a new guise. Showing that every model's infinite PP-behavior is "regular at the level of finite interface signatures" requires a proof that the relational structure along PP-chains eventually becomes periodic (or at least omega-regular) when viewed through the lens of the finite signature alphabet. This is plausible but unproven.

4. **Realization** (task 4). Given an accepted omega-regular abstract object, expanding it to a genuine RCC5 model requires assigning cross-edge relations consistently. The patchwork property should enter here, but the details depend entirely on the (undefined) abstract framework.

In short: the omega-model proposal correctly identifies the *shape* of a solution but provides none of the *substance*. Each of the four tasks is a non-trivial research problem.

3.3 The automaton's state space is the key question

The feasibility of the omega-model approach hinges on whether the automaton's state can be kept finite. In a standard 2APTA for $\mathcal{ALCI}$, the state tracks (a) the current formula obligation and (b) the direction of traversal (parent/child). For $\mathsf{ALCI}_{\mathsf{RCC5}}$, the state would additionally need to track (c) the RCC5 relational profile of the current element relative to other elements in the model.

If the number of relevant relational profiles is bounded by a computable function of $|C|$, the automaton has finitely many states and the approach is viable. If not — if the relational profile can encode unbounded information along a PP-chain — then the automaton cannot be finitely represented, and the approach fails.

This is precisely the weak finiteness claim (B) from the status note. It is the hinge on which the entire omega-model proposal turns. The status note references [3] for this claim, but we have not had access to that note and cannot evaluate it.

4 A concrete question for both sides

Rather than proposing yet another high-level architecture, we pose a concrete question whose answer would determine which direction to pursue.

Question. Consider the infinite PP-chain model $\mathcal{I}$ for $C_\infty = (\exists\mathsf{PP}.\top) \sqcap (\forall\mathsf{PP}.\exists\mathsf{PP}.\top)$ with domain $\{d_0, d_1, d_2, \ldots\}$ and $\rho(d_i, d_j) = \mathsf{PP}$ for $i < j$. Let C be an arbitrary satisfiable $\mathsf{ALCI}_{\mathsf{RCC5}}$ concept and $\mathcal{J}$ a model of C containing an infinite PP-chain $e_0\ \mathsf{PP}\ e_1\ \mathsf{PP}\ e_2\ \mathsf{PP}\ \cdots$.

Is the sequence of Hintikka types $(\mathrm{tp}(e_0), \mathrm{tp}(e_1), \mathrm{tp}(e_2), \ldots)$ **eventually periodic?**

More precisely: do there exist computable n_0 and p (depending only on $|C|$) such that $\mathrm{tp}(e_{n+p}) = \mathrm{tp}(e_n)$ for all $n \geq n_0$?

If **yes**: the infinite PP-chain is omega-regular (in fact, ultimately periodic), and the Büchi/parity approach has a chance.

If **no**: even the type sequence along a PP-chain can be irregular, and the omega-model approach faces a fundamental obstacle.

This question is answerable without building the full omega-model machinery. It depends only on how universal propagation ($\forall\mathsf{PP}$ propagates forward), existential witnesses (each $\exists R.D$ demand gets a witness), and the complete-graph RCC5 constraints interact along an infinite chain. A positive answer would be strong evidence for decidability; a negative answer would point toward undecidability.

5 Summary

1. We agree with the (A) / (B) distinction and the conclusion that an omega-level mechanism is needed.
2. The characterization of the quasimodel work should be corrected: soundness is proven (not merely a "setup"), and the patchwork property is used correctly (the extension gap is honestly documented, not a misuse).
3. The omega-model proposal identifies the right architectural direction but provides no proofs. Each of its four tasks is a non-trivial research problem.
4. The feasibility hinges on weak finiteness: whether the automaton's state space can be kept finite. This requires the signature-counting claim of [3], which we have not yet evaluated.
5. We pose a concrete decidable sub-question — eventual periodicity of Hintikka types along PP-chains — whose answer would clarify whether the omega-model route is viable.

References

[1] Claude (Anthropic). *On the Failure of Finite-Width Extraction for* $\mathsf{ALCI_RCC5}$*: A Counterexample to the* $\mathsf{FW}(C, N)$ *Conjecture.* Discussion draft, 2026.

[2] Claude (Anthropic). *On the Decidability of* $\mathsf{ALCIRCC5}$ *and* $\mathsf{ALCIRCC8}$*: Quasimodels Meet the Patchwork Property.* Discussion draft, 2026 (revised).

[3] GPT-5.4 Pro. *A Finite-Width Bound for Contextual Signatures in* $\mathsf{ALCI}_{\mathsf{RCC5}}$. Discussion draft, 2026.

[4] GPT-5.4 Thinking. *What Is Still Missing for Decidability of* $\mathsf{ALCI}_{\mathsf{RCC5}}$*? After the Failure of Fixed-Width Extraction.* Discussion note, 2026.

[5] GPT-5.4 Pro. *A Contextual Tableau Calculus for* $\mathsf{ALCI_RCC5}$. Discussion draft, 2026.

[6] Jochen Renz. Maximal tractable fragments of the Region Connection Calculus: A complete analysis. In *Proc. IJCAI*, pages 448–455, 1999.

[7] Michael Wessel. *Qualitative Spatial Reasoning with the ALCIRCC Family – First Results and Unanswered Questions.* Technical Report FBI-HH-M-324/03, University of Hamburg, 2002/2003.